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Chairman, Apeejay Surrendra Group

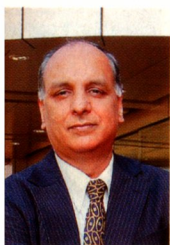


Globalisation has changed the business environment, he feels. "People work harder, longer and there's more pressure to perform." To unwind, he zips around in his sports car and sips red wine after a hard day's work.

With Blackberries and laptops, it's hard to switch-off from work.

R. CHANDRASEKARAN

President and MD, Cognizant

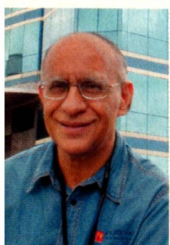


"Stress can be positive," thinks this head honcho. That doesn't stop him from taking off for exotic destinations or jotting down his experiences. But it's music, listening or composing, that soothes his soul, he says.

Indian CEOs may work hard, but they work smart, too.

ASHOK SOOTA

Chairman and CEO, MindTree



He logs in 70 hours a week at work, but doesn't believe Indian CEOs are stressed out. Why? "We are operating in a high growth environment. Positive results are the best antidote for stress." For him, yoga helps.

Stress is a way of life. You just have to take it in your stride.

have extraordinary coping skills. That's how they got where they are." But the orientation to action that so distinguishes them, can work spectacularly against them when problems arise. It prevents them from getting help, or even recognising they need it, he thinks. "When they begin to have some kind of symptoms of stress, they don't think of it in terms of an illness, but as emanating from other circumstances in their life. Their initial reaction is often anger at the people under them." Moreover, the modern corporation is structured to give CEOs wealth and power, but also crushing isolation. "These people may, in fact, be even more vulnerable to stress and depression than others. The tendency to build their identity on achievement makes a downturn unbearable," says Trehan.

But what exactly is stress? Consider this. It's the beginning of another working day. The 52-year-old CEO of a telecom retail venture in Bangalore hurries out of his apartment into the roar of the morning rush hour. Late for work, he squeezes the car through snarling traffic, fuming at every red light. He opens the office door and finds his secretary frantic. The report due to be sent to the US client is still not complete, and the client is furious. He sits down, his stomach churning, his back muscles knotting, his blood pressure climbing. He summons the unit manager responsible for the job and shouts, "If you value your job, you had better have a good explanation. And, by the way, you can forget about taking a vacation this summer." The man continues to spout excuses. He eyes a paperweight on his desk and longs to throw it at him. Instead, the CEO reaches for a Prozac and has a sudden yearning for a stiff drink, straight up.

He is under terrific stress. His company is in the grips of powerful global competitive pressure, internal restructuring and a string of acquisitions. Unending international travel, combined with family concerns—ageing

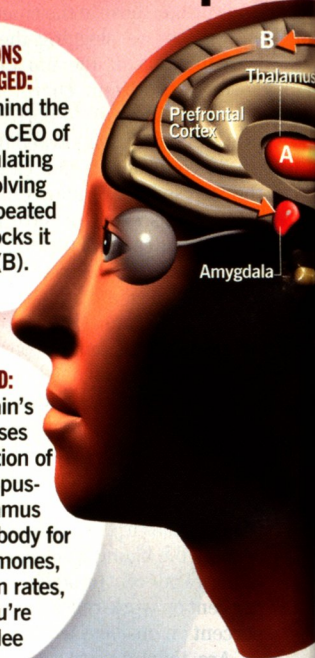
Is the workplace

DECISIONS DISENGAGED:

The area behind the forehead is the CEO of the brain, regulating judgement, solving problems. Repeated stress knocks it offline (B).

EMOTIONS ENGAGED:

Amygdala, the brain's emotional core, raises alarm at every perception of threat. The hippocampus-brainstem-hypothalamus nexus—mobilises the body for action: a flood of hormones, faster heart-respiration rates, tense muscles. You're ready to fight or flee (A).



parents and a troubled teenager—also take the toll. For 10 years, he has suffered from high cholesterol and high blood pressure. Since both are significant risk factors for heart disease and stroke, his doctor has prescribed a simple treatment, "reduce your stress". But how? He always feels too flattened with exhaustion.

What has been happening to him? The December 2001 issue of the *Harvard Business Review* explains his condition. The brain's mood-management centre contains two circuits: one depends on connections to other people, and the other transmits neurological, hormonal, blood pressure and electromagnetic messaging among organs within the body. In the case of our telecom CEO, constant stress has hijacked the latter. How? The answer lies in the emotional centre of the brain, or the amygdala, whose job is to look for a match between the memory of a past experience and an event now. If a colleague ignores or is curt with him, his amygdala remembers the negative experience; then, when he receives an